This project uses an interactive chatbox format to highlight the communication disparity between human and computer by re-translating the interactor's own words. By playing with the user's relationship with technology, words, and meaning, the chatbot doesn't output simple replies or really anything of overt use. Instead it becomes a sort of playground where the user is both with and without control of the program's output.

In Zach Whalen's "Any Means Necessary," the line "[this] gap between what a human means and what a computer understands is the challenge that novice programmers learn to struggle against: just because a line of code makes sense to me does not mean that the computer will do with it what I think it will" (Whalen, 2023) sowed the seeds to this project. Specifically, just because the user types something that makes sense, doesn't mean the computer will understand it. In the context of this project I wanted to broaden the meaning of constraints, breaking free from the idea of limiting the computer's responses to a specific poem structure or even just making a chatbot to mimic an LLM. Instead the responses the user receives are random, near-gibberish and seemingly pointless in nature.

In a way "The Policeman's Beard is Half Constructed" by Racter also aided in the conception of this idea. A computer being able to create prose that (although it uses words) is a bit nonsensical but likely made sense only to that program was an interesting concept to pivot off of. This program capitalizes on this by really only making sense to the computer. Only the computer understands what it's doing with the language provided. It's legible enough, but there's no lexicographical explanation. Either it makes sense through pure coincidence or it doesn't make sense at all.

I feel like art always lives in this zone of being lost in translation. When art and coding meet, I find that the valley of misinterpretation only widens. I used the format of a chatbot to subvert the user's expectations of "meaningful communication" especially in an era where chatbots are made to feel more human. By taking the user's input and converting it to binary, the binary is then scrambled and new letters are derived from this remix of language. But only language meaningful to a layman is returned. I chose this specific method after playing around with a few different iterations because I found more meaning in the computer taking the user's words to weaponize confusion. The computer is not only constrained to the user's input to create a response, it's constrained to producing an output the user can visually understand. It's designed to play almost like a game of telephone where there's no correlation between the conclusion and the original phrase or action.

Without context, I want this program to confuse and almost irritate the user. I want to evoke the feeling of being heard but not understood, of having a conversation that leads nowhere. I want the program to reflect the process of its creation, fighting with the computer to derive something meaningful. Whether or not the user is able to autonomously extract the algorithm behind the code, I want this to eventually become a playground. Where frustration ends and curiosity begins, where it's almost exciting if a "real word" is output. I have fallen victim to the belief that there is only meaning if I can understand. Through the development of this project, it sooner became a lesson in embracing chaos.

One topic that's been broached in class has been the idea of author intent versus viewer perception. And to me, this ties in perfectly with this idea of programmer meaning and computer understanding and even on an even broader scale, human meaning and computer understanding. Initially, I had the computer output a confusing mess of 1's and 0's but I didn't want to force the user to work for information and directly translate. Although it fit the theme of miscommunication, I felt it was more impactful to only include “readable” characters, as if the computer is trying to communicate but is unable to parse meaning.

Purposefully omitting the features of an LLM returns some authorship to the user, where they are, to some degree, responsible for the output. The element of randomness creates a diverse range of outputs across users and allows them to derive their own meaning from the project without my imposition. This program purposefully isn’t smart; its only goal is to create a purposeful distance between what the user intends and what the computer chooses to understand.

References

Whalen, Z. (2023). “Any Means Necessary to Refuse Erasure by Algorithm:” Lillian-Yvonne Bertram’s Travesty Generator. *Digital Humanities Quarterly*, *17*(2). https://doi.org/10.63744/nj5ge4mj39t9